Melancholy

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42379344.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Angella & Glimmer (She-Ra), Glimmer & Micah (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
minor glimbow due to puppy crush, Partial Mind Control, Mind Manipulation, Blood and Gore, on screen death, Gun Violence, Racism, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Child Neglect, Parent-Child Relationship, Angella's A+ parenting, Isolation, house arrest, no editing we die like meh, glimmer pov, I love momgella but this fic does not have her, Alternate Universe - Bloodborne Fusion, Don't Have to Know Bloodborne (Video Game), I am seriously getting fast and loose with the lore now, wrote this outline back when I subscribed to a different interpretation than I do now, my bad - Freeform

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Part 4 of We are born of the blood

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by Nny11

Summary

Glimmer knew this would be her only chance to escape. Her only chance to do something, anything with her life. After all, it wasn't as if she would become queen of Brightmoon when her mother could survive and regenerate after any attack against her. No, she would be a princess eternal if she didn't leave to become something of value.

What good is a princess who cannot protect, when there are hunters out there in need of fresh blood?

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Princess Glimmer of Brightmoon, first born of the eternal Queen Angella of the Angelblood, was scheming.

It was not an unusual state of affairs by any means, but this time she was sure it would work! It had to, she had to finally do something besides worthlessly laze about the castle or be held prisoner in her own room. Glimmer knew this would be her only chance to escape. Her only chance to do something, anything with her life. After all, it wasn't as if she would become queen of Brightmoon when her mother could survive and regenerate after any attack against her. No, she would be a princess eternal if she didn't leave to become something of value, even if it meant becoming more like her father, a thought which made her heart race.

She knew it was uncharitable of her to loathe her own father, but she felt quite justified.

When Glimmer had been very young, she used to cry when her daddy left. King Consort Micah, the Provost of Mystacor, was a busy man who never was able to stay with them. He visited as often as he could, but to someone so young a quarter year might as well have been a century. She loved her daddy, he was warm and kind and full of laughter. He would scoop her up to make her "fly" and shower her in kisses to make up for all the ones he couldn't give her while he was away. She loved him and looked up to him, and a handful of letters were not the same when read out by her reserved mother. Angella was not cruel back then, but she was also not Micah.

Glimmer knows that when she was four she had begged and pleaded with her mother to make daddy stay. To order him to stay. Any order from Angella to one who drank her blood was bound to be completed, the magic within the angel blood would ensure it. If she told Micah he had to stay, then her daddy would have no choice and they could be together always! When it didn't work she'd then begged to instead be sent where he went. The queen had not liked that much, eyes sharp and hard before softening again. And they both promised her, they swore to her, that she could live part of the year with her father at the college. Her daddy told her grand stories of the beautiful school and all the amazing magical things he would teach her. Stories that filled her impressionable mind with hope and joy.

And for one glorious week it had all been true, the fantasy and dream made real.

Mystacor was a beautiful place, peaceful and calm where Brightmoon could be smothering in either endless social functions or a dreary sort of silence. The forest was fun to play in (even just around the edge where she was allowed), the lake held all sorts of water fowl, and her daddy began to teach her a basic spell to create a light orb. She had been so excited to see her father's office and weapons, she watched the hunters come and go from the tunnels, and she listened into every lecture she could. It felt like her mind, always racing, had finally calmed with enough novel input. Glimmer had been so happy. It was truly a perfect world.

After that first week, her dream had been ruthlessly crushed.

"I'm sorry baby girl, I know we promised you could stay here, but things aren't well in Etheria. It's becoming dangerous for anyone

to be nearby, and we are very close to them." He kneeled on the ground, rocking her back and forth as she cried into his purple and blue robes. "You can come back as soon as it's safe, I promise."

She was desperate to keep him, to keep this sliver of joy alive. "Th-then you come with me! If it's not safe, you have to come too!"

He'd smiled at her so sadly and indulgently and condescendingly. "I'm afraid I can't, I'm one of the few people who can help make it safer. But I have to stay here to do it. Don't worry, I'm well protected!"

She'd stared miserably at the tonitrus he wore from his belt, and hated it. Deeply and desperately and fully, she **hated** what it stood for.

Powerless to stop it, Glimmer was escorted to the small town where a carriage picked her up and took her back to the castle. But with a taste of freedom her former life felt stifling. Even at so young an age the experience had stuck with her, a maddening sort of knowledge. Her mother became more short and frustrated and Glimmer lashed out, acted out, did anything she could to gain a shadow of it back. When that proved futile she turned back to her father, hoping to at least have that bright, warm connection back. She wrote to him as often as she'd been able to, first with help and then all on her own as she grew up without him, always asking when she could go back. Soon, he would write, soon.

And soon became eventually, became I promise someday, became a silent unspoken never.

It wasn't *safe* enough for poor, delicate little Glimmer. Only the castle was protected these days, so it would be best if she was a good little girl and accepted her dull fate.

Bitter and slowly withering away her mother's patience, Glimmer had eventually cracked under order to tell her why she was behaving in an unbecoming manner. The answer made her mother sigh, some fight leaving her. Angella had insisted that she be patient. They both missed Micah, and he missed them. The assurances rang insincerely when her father no longer came to the dream to see them each day. A simple matter that would take no more than a half hour of his busy time even just once a week, but no. He was too busy and too important for Glimmer now. The dream felt stifling with nothing left within it but her own hateful longing so she stopped going. Then it finally happened that the letters eventually dried up. No more missives, stories, or even spells sent. No more "I miss you", "I love you", "I hope to be home soon". Oh that wasn't fair was it, Glimmer rolled her eyes a bit, his letters hadn't *stopped* only the ones he sent Glimmer ceased. Her mother received regular correspondence that never seemed to mention his only child at all. And after a year of hopefully asking after him, she finally gave up much to her mother's apparent relief.

With her parents being silent, the lonely princess instead began speaking with anyone who was visiting their city from Etheria. She'd been warned that nothing good could come of it, that it was best to leave the poor sods alone, but it was the only way to possibly learn more about the hunt that was allegedly both out of control but tamed, small but dangerous, harmless and deadly. It

had torn her family apart, it kept them apart still, and she had a right to know what could possibly be so important! Poking and prodding for information took time, her patience rewarded when she found the right drunken aristocrat who had been delighted to speak of their adventures hunting in the unforgiving walled city.

"They come out at night, worst of them on the full moon. Beasts! All sorts too! Big and small, with fangs and claws. Some with poison and others with powers beyond comprehension." The woman had slurred. "Got myself a blood starved one! Crushed and then burned, the way it ought to be I tell you. No chance to come back from that, eh?"

Desperate as she was for attention and tales, Glimmer had absorbed it all like a sponge. Asking question after question about the monsters born from the Etherians themselves, their beastly insides becoming their outsides before being violently hunted down by the Horde.

"Stand up folks!" The woman nodded vigorously, as if she was agreeing with someone else about it. "That Healing Horde is powerful and filled with the wrath of the gods themselves. I think I'll join them soon, the thrill of the hunt is…well, ha! It's unimaginable to you I'd suspect. But don't fear I've taken my precautions," She had flexed her metal studded gloves and patted at the bands around her right leg as if that could hide the obvious staining from all the blood, "and there isn't a drop of Etherian blood in me either, which should help the most!"

Sure, Glimmer had nightmares for weeks afterwards about strange wolf-like creatures dragging her from her bed to be feasted on by spiders with human heads while her parents

watched blandly from the side, but Glimmer had appreciated the woman's candor the older she'd gotten. In a way it had helped soothe some of the bitter rage she held towards her father, instead growing an admiration that he was out there hunting as well and a deep desire to join him. It felt logical. If the beasts made it dangerous, and hunting made it safer, then the best way for her to escape Brightmoon and her mother's iron fist was by becoming a hunter alongside her father. Together they would slay more beasts than anyone else and bring peace!

Her mother had not been so keen on the idea.

"Absolutely not." She dismissed it, as she did every idea or proposal Glimmer brought her. "It's much too dangerous, and I won't have you thinking you are invincible just because you have some awful weapon to bludgeon the beasts with. Focus on your learning."

Glimmer could feel her heart stutter as the magic inside her turned against her. Her jaw ached, clenched tight as a headache brewed, the hissing and whispering growing until she gave in as always. "I will focus on my learning."

"As you should."

Perhaps it would hurt less if her mother would at least seem to notice the orders she gave, but Queen Angella no longer seemed to care. Where she was careful for her phrasing amongst their people, at home and in private she pulled the strings connecting them without even a passing thought.. Glimmer was supposed to

be polite to the nobles, and so she often found her tongue saying something much different than she wanted to. Glimmer was supposed to stay safe, so any perceived danger was cause to keep her in line even as she begged her body to move. She was to keep distance between herself at the rabble, and so no matter how lonely she was Glimmer made no friends. On and on such small orders went, until she was technically free to do anything she wished as long as it did not contradict her mother's wants.

Like always, Glimmer gave it a second thought. The orders she received where thoughtless and that meant they were vague. As long as she didn't let herself think too fully on it she could work her way around the spirit of it and follow the letter instead. There was no risk of being outed by her mother's questioning or curiosity. With the queen barely present in her life, it took nothing to slip past her unfocused gaze to go to the yards where knights and guards trained to focus on her learning and ensure she was safer than she was before. Two birds, one stone. She had watched them enviously for years as other nobles were allowed to learn, knowing that someone would report her back surely. This time, Glimmer knew better. Her mother did not care or watch, and the people here were loyal to both her mother and her. It took a little doing to find General Juliette, a hard woman with a golden core, and then convince her that she should be trained too. She'd been forced to accept a reiterpallasch to learn with, it was the weapon of the nobility after all, but with it in her hand the world once more came to life.

The days felt faster as Glimmer dedicated herself to her training. The burn of muscles and careful calculation in sparring matches giving her something to look forward to, to improve upon for an end goal and purpose. Learning to handle the weapon itself had brought a spark of joy as well, the forms and maintenance giving her time to slow down and focus. Working along side other nobles gave her the chance to speak with those her mother found good

enough, without making it a political maneuver. It was almost the way she imaged it felt to make friends, even if the constant turn over of trainees meant she never spoke with any too long. Juliette kept a keen eye on her, checking her stance and form, running her through more advanced techniques as she outstripped the rest. Transforming the blade to use the firearm inside was delicate and if done improperly could jam the firing mechanism. Glimmer spent hours each night learning to smoothly and safely switch between the two modes, eager for her chance to actually use the gun. It was a bit of a rude awakening when she tried it the first time, and despite the General's warnings wrenched her wrist from the recoil. Practice, practice, practice, until it was doable even though it could rarely be properly aimed. By then she'd outstripped the nobles entirely, joining those working towards their knighthoods with long barreled pistols in their off hands and even the occasional use of a phantasm shell.

Juliette had smirked at her, proudly commenting, “At this rate I think a knighthood might be around the corner, your highness.”

It flushed her with pride to hear, boosting her self confidence to consider. After all, what was a princess but a protector of her people? And Princess Glimmer was determined to protect, cocksure in her skills and knowing she could turn the tide of the hunt if given a chance.

The scourge was barely contained those days, the news of it finally spreading beyond the immediate affected areas, but the hunt kept it manageable enough for people to live their lives. She’d been very sure that someone like her, with her training in tactics and now the blade, with her untapped magical potential and angel blood, could stop the horrors from growing or spreading. It had not yet reached Brightmoon’s shores but

Glimmer would rather die than let it ravage her people. A knighthood would be undeniable proof of her abilities, surely her mother would see reason with it. And then Glimmer could make a new faction of hunters, Brightmoon Hunters who knew blood better than anyone else, and they could be heroes! Keep their home free of such an awful fate by saving Etheria. And then- oh and then! The people would be gracious and grateful to their saviors. Perhaps they would see reason then too, finally bend the knee to her mother and be lifted up from their own squalor into a more civilized and sophisticated life. In an ideal world her mother would recognize Glimmer as an equal, smart and brave and strong, and let her rule over their new protectorate. It would be a dream come true to put all of her training in politics and leadership into proper use away from her mother's crushing influence, and it would all be to better Brightmoon’s holdings and safety.

Sometimes, when she was feeling lost and longing at night, she imagined what life would be like then. Her father could pledge Mystacor to the crown as well, and they could all rule together. She sometimes caught herself crying as she pictured all three of them discussing various bills and laws over a meal. Happy. Free and safe and finally able to be together.

It had all been very idealistic of her. A last dying gasp of some youthful naïveté.

Foolish, ignorant, and sheltered of her to assume so much already.

No beasts in Brightmoon? Glimmer snorted at her younger self’s stupidity for buying the lie. Oh, but she had fallen for it until two

years ago, when it had all come crashing down around her. Some part of dying the day she watched a knight kill a Brightmoon beast.

The elderly man was a withered noble, using a threaded cane to hobble about and as a way to keep his knighthood by keeping a weapon on his person despite the fact that he was unfit to fight. Pompous and resistant to any change, Lord Mondschatten was sure he knew better than anyone in the whole world. Like many amongst their court, he most likely only stayed for the benefits afforded the court instead of retiring quietly to his manor. The only way to regularly partake of the royal blood, a leash he surely saw as a reward. A craving he would never shake, a thirst he could never slake.

His doublet was torn wide open to make room for his now swollen, red belly. He'd eyed the two of them as they approached, the knight doing their duty and the Princess shadowing under them for the day. She didn't even know their name, it was the first time they'd ever worked together as Juliette had fallen ill that morning. Glimmer had looked to the knight and they had whispered to her, "Your highness please, remain behind me and let me handle it."

Lord Mondschatten had swayed on his feet, hissing as they approached and skittering backwards until they had literally cornered him along the castle's exterior wall. His eyes were wide and glassy as he looked between them. Scared but unseeing as he moaned in pain and tore at his clothes.

"My lord, please." The knight spoke gently, their voice light and almost airy. "Let me-"

“Stay away! The both of you!” He snarled, groaning in pain as his stomach rumbled. “I- I demand to see the queen! I must see her. She cheated me of her blood, cheated me of it! Send her here at once!”

Glimmer had rolled her eyes at him. To make a demand to see the queen, ha! Queen Angella bent to no mortal. He must be suffering fever too, perhaps an infection in his stomach?

The knight took a half step forward, one hand extended as if to help Mondschatten out into the sunlight. “She gave you as much as always, my lord.”

“NO!” He shrieked, spittle flying from his lips and dribbling as his body twitched violently. “No, she **cheated** me! I need more, a proper and filling drink!”

Glimmer stared on in disgust as he pulled clumps of his own hair out, thick fistfuls of it showing a gray skin underneath it. She had seen him just that morning receive a second drink, and wondered what her mother’s knowing look had been about. Perhaps he had become addicted to the blood, the way the Etherians did? He was stubborn but always had a weak constitution.

The knight’s kept one hand extended while the other drifted to their sword, their voice still placating despite the obvious threat. “My lord, you had enough.”

It was more aggressive than Glimmer thought warranted, but they had done this more often than she.

“No, you aren’t listening to me! Bastard! I NEED more. I... I **need**... ” His watering eyes roved about until they finally focused on her, a disturbing smile flowed across his face. “Your highness, her blood is in you. You can give me what I need. Please, it is but a humble request.”

Glimmer blanched, and be skinned alive for giving out a sacrament meant only to be given by the queen? She did not give her blood as it would split loyalties. He was delusional! “A request only my mother can fulfill.”

It all happened so fast.

“Inside of you,” he whispered a small strand of drool hanging from his chin and moaned again in pain, “I’m starving. I’m starving to death and you refuse me that which grants me life? Ungrateful little brat.” There was a horrible cracking sound as his arms broke in half and began to grow rapidly. "Just a sip, that's all I need! You bitch, just a SIP!" His skin became tighter and white as snow, eyes rolling up in his head. “You will **give it to me**!” He coughed, retching as his tongue rolling out of his mouth and growing far too long. Glimmer had stood in shock and horror as she realized what was happening, even if her mind refused to name it so.

Without any preamble or care, almost slowly for how fluid and calm they were, the knight stabbed their blade into his throat, pulled the trigger, and killed him instantly. Blood sprayed across the wall of the castle, chunks of skull and flesh sliding to ground as the body slumped into a heap. Glimmer stared, frozen and helpless, as blood poured from the pulp that remained of Lord Mondschatten's head. She followed the small rivers with her eyes as it pooled around the body, hot enough to steam in the brisk morning air.

The knight seemed to not care, almost to not notice what they had done. Pulling their blade free smoothly and chuckling, “Fucking finally, always frustrating when they drag it out like that. Sorry you had to deal with a long one first, but I’m sure neither of us will miss that old windbag, eh?”

Glimmer said nothing as they wiped their blade clean, eyes burning as the body began to rapidly decompose until nothing was left but a few scraps of tattered clothing. Not even dust left. Just scraps of cloth and blood.

“You can normally tell who’s time is almost up,” they continued a slight swagger to their step as they began to kick loose soil over the mess left behind. “They want more than their fair share, greedy dogs. I tell you now, most of them have got some lesser blood inside their veins if you know what I mean. Still, horrible way to go. Usually it goes much faster, I assure you this was unusual.”

She barely noticed the pause as she watched a few leaves fall onto the newly overturned dirt. It was as if it never happened, the

spatter against the wall the only sign that anything had happened at all.

"Your highness?" The knight called to her, finally drawing her gaze to their sympathetic own. "My apologies, Princess. I'm afraid I've grown too used to this duty and forgot this was the first you've seen, isn't it?"

She hated how careful they were now, how kind seeming as they nearly reached out to grab her shoulders before reconsidering it. They were a good person. She'd really believed that, it was just hard to keep in mind when she'd seen how brutal the kill was. How efficient.

Glimmer had known, of course she'd *known* , that beasts were once humans. Somehow she'd disconnected the thought in her head, allowing the monsters to be more fiction than real. The Lord Mondschatten hadn't attacked them, hadn't shown any violent motives towards them, but he would have though. Allowed to leave and live, he would have. All at once every unkind thought she'd held for him turned with guilt in her stomach. He'd been hurting, needing help, not death. If they could tell in advance was there truly nothing that could be done? Not even a poison slipped in sleep to ease their death? Gods she felt like a fool.

"Yes," she almost whispered before clearing her throat, "How often do you…handle this sort of situation?"

They motioned for her to walk with them once more across the grounds. "About once every few months here at the castle. In the

city proper? At least every week, the cowards fleeing here from across the water are certainly bringing their sickness with them.”

The whole affair had taken perhaps three minutes from start to finish, which, in an interesting turn of fate, was about how long her argument with her mother lasted that afternoon.

It turned out such incidents were always reported to the crown, including who was present to witness it. As such her mother learned the truth of where Glimmer had been spending her time the last several years, the trainings she'd undertaken, and now the secrets that had been revealed to her.

Queen Angella had kept her quiet in public, calling for Glimmer to attend to her. She waited until the doors were closed to unleash her fury, it battered against her heart and mind, hissing and screaming soundlessly in her ears but not so loudly as to block out her mother's yelling.

“You disobeyed me!”

“You told me to focus on learning and I have been learning! Meanwhile **you** have been **lying**, endangering our people and-”

Angella’s wings flared wide with indignation. “Watch your tone with me young lady. You knew I didn’t want you fighting and went behind my back, and now you accuse me of lying? Pray tell, who have I been lying to?”

“EVERYONE!” Glimmer shouted, flinging her hands in the air. “Brightmoon is not safe from the scourge when our own turn in the streets. The people have a right to know, we have to warn them!”

Somehow her mother stood even taller, imperious as she pressed her hands together, it was a queenly pose. A shift from her concerned mother to a cold queen. “Glimmer, we have shared the blood for centuries. They are more than aware of the dangers and what will happen should they lose control of this gift. You and I are immune, there is nothing to fear.”

She’d laughed, harsh and jagged, “What about those who don’t swear the oath? Do they know? The knight said every week someone turns in the city and they don't drink of your blood! We **must**-”

“Ensure we do not incite panic.” Her mother’s voice was like stone. “We are safe and the mainland grows ever more dangerous. If the citizens of Brightmoon learn the truth, that a very small handful of their fellows become beasts, they will flee straight into a far greater danger than they would leave. This is for the best.”

“How can you say that? That it’s safe here when the knights kill our own?”

“It **is** safe, and you will not share what you have learned. We do not need the dangers of self proclaimed hunters within our walls!”

It was a slap to the face. For her memories, her dreams, her hopes. “Father is a hunter, they are helping cull the beasts. Or that’s what you said. Was that a lie too?”

“Glimmer!” The queen had gasped as if she’d said something unconscionable. “I will not be spoken to that way.”

“What way!?” She’d all but howled, crying openly now as her emotions tangled up too brightly inside her chest. “Like you aren’t all knowing? What you’re doing is wrong and-”

“As your queen I am ordering you to keep this secret, and that is the end of that!” Her mother, her queen, her commander, strode to the doors and summoned her personal guards to escort the princess to her room. She knew better than to expect capitulation in the heat of the moment, and sent Glimmer away to prevent her from suffering needlessly.

As if she would not simply sit in her room, feeling as if she was being boiled alive from the inside out until her own rage calmed. As if she would not demand Glimmer swear a new vow as the Princess of Brightmoon, as if it would not make her daughter ache for hours afterwards when she refused. The only one who could fight it, she was morally obligated to fight it, she deserved to fight back against such an unjust and awful demand. It was not the first time her mother had imprisoned her this way, with guards barring her from leaving and no one being allowed to speak with her. If her own mother was not the one dragging out the torture instead of overwhelming her into submission, the isolation would crush her spirit. She always bent the knee in the end, there was

no choice to make or option to change, often leaving after a week at the most to her mother's chiding, "You did this to yourself."

But this time? Oh this time was different. Her mother's fury truly too deep to even attempt to speak with her. And so one day became two became a week became more. Glimmer watched the seasons change, always waking to find food and water left, her chamber pot cleaned, and no trace of whoever had done it. She waited, swinging between fighting and agreeing simply to have it done with, but the queen never came. Winter passed and come the spring she feared her mother had simply forgotten she existed. Angella had once told her time blurred a bit for her after she hit a thousand years old, it simply did not mean the same thing to her as to the rest. Had she been forgotten? Glimmer spent much of the spring trying to beat down the thick door to her room, screaming until she was hoarse, tearing everything apart she could get her hands on only to wake the next morning to a pristine space once more. She was certain she would die there. She'd been sure of it!

Glimmer stood with her eyes closed and face turned up towards the unusually weak summer sun, letting her fingers run over the grass she sat on and held back her tears. Breathing slowly to let the fear and pain and the loneliness go. It was not her first day free from imprisonment and crying would be unsightly, and she would not risk her mother sending her back into isolation when her very salvation would come so soon. But gods it was hard. She was angry and scared and still clung to hope with both her fists.

Yes, she'd been released for one reason only. There was a small group of scholars from the world library were coming. The visit had been planned out three years before and they expected to see the royal family, not just the queen. Her mother never was

one to lose face or present an image she did not wish. One day Glimmer had awoken to find her mother sitting at her desk, and thought she been hallucinating until Angella spoke.

"The scholars will be here within the next few days. Will you keep the crown's secrets?"

She must have been half mad, emboldened by some unseen force even as the angel blood began to sing inside of her. It hurt, gods it ached, and she nearly craved it after so long. "For how long?"

Her mother had smiled, chuckling as if this were a simple discussion and not a hellish exercise. "Brazen still, my daughter. Perhaps a stalemate for now, hm? Will you swear to abide by my demands, swearing an oath to silence for the duration of their visit? Afterwards we can revisit a long term oath, or if you have enjoyed yourself her so much we can let you return to it once more. What say you?"

She would've been a fool not to take it. A temporary gag order was better than a long term binding, and Glimmer had no plans to give the queen a chance to ask again. This was her last chance to live, to survive. If she did not flee now, she would not be strong enough to return to solitary confinement. But her very soul refused to let her rest, not when the scourge was already here.

So, she planned and schemed.

Once upon a time her fall back had been to go to her father in Mystacor, where all were welcomed. But he cared so little for her these days that he hadn't even written for her birthday. He had drunk the blood and sworn his oath as well, which left him firmly under her mother's angelic control. Between the two Glimmer knew it was worthless to try. If she managed to get there, he would only send her back and she knew for a fact that returning would mean being forced to become her mother's puppet. She knew the orders would come quickly, overriding her own will and mind in order for the queen to have the fake family she wanted so dearly. She, truly, would rather die.

No staying in Brightmoon or on the island, no Mystacor college or even the forest just to be safe. Etheria was just about her only other option, as leaving too far risked being unable to return and achieve the only goal that still mattered to her. Stop the scourge and save the people. Glimmer refused to be a princess, could not be a mage, and so she would be a hunter if it killed her.

She only need escape Brightmoon, and her plan would succeed simply because she could not afford to fail.

A tip-less arrow dropped down, next to her with a small scroll attached and it made her smile. Speak of the devil. Glimmer quickly picked it up and opened it to reveal a simple message with simple drawings in it.

Hey Glimmer! <3

“Bow!” She laughed, turning to look at the boy who had apparently thrown the arrow by hand so as to not risk injuring her despite never apparently missing a shot. “You could always just say hello aloud like a normal person!”

“Aw, c’mon, that wouldn’t be as much fun!” Without needing an invitation, without worrying about distance or orders, treating her as an equal, Bow walked forward and flopped down close enough for their legs to touch.

She felt her whole body warm and smiled fondly at him. "Well I can't argue with that."

He was the best thing that had possibly ever happened to her.

Bow was the son of the visiting scholars, or at least one of them. While his father George was a retired hunter and well equipped to protect them, Bow had accompanied them for the trip due to danger of passing through Etheria which was still a necessity should one wish to cross the bridge to the castle. On his back was a trick weapon of his own design, a blade that could turn quickly into a recurved bow and one he’d already shown his skill in to entertain the royals on the first day of their arrival. He was bright and open, with a heart too big for Brightmoon. Glimmer was growing more enamored with him every day.

That first evening Bow had watched her very carefully and the next morning simply acted as if they’d known one another their whole lives. When prodded he’d smiled sadly at her, “Forgive me if

I’m wrong, you just seemed lonely. Life’s hard enough, so I thought it wouldn’t hurt either of us to make a new friend.”

She hadn't believed him then. Suspecting her mother's influence or his own political devices. Being friendly but never open until he’d lied to her mother on her behalf, it had made her heart do a strange little stutter. No one lied to Queen Angella, and no one had ever intervened to protect Glimmer in such a manner either.

“I was showing her how the mechanism works in my bowblade!” Bow had smiled brightly at the queen when she caught them mere minutes after they’d finished sparing. Glimmer had been bored to tears and lamenting missing her time in the yards, and Bow had offered to train with her towards the back corner of the castle grounds were a copse of trees blocked line of sight, going so far as to borrow his father's spear for her to use. The spear itself was, luckily enough, flung behind a bush just out of sight where Glimmer had playfully thrown it in a farce for losing that had Bow laughing so hard he'd cried. Now her little charade was saving her.

“Out here instead of at the yards?” the queen drawled, staring at her daughter before demanding, “What were you really doing out here?”

Glimmer’s blood sang and she let herself relax into it, it was easier to manipulate if you didn’t fight it. “He really was showing me how the bow blade works, I was curious and knew you’d assume I was fighting if you saw us.”

It had been close, and the queen clearly didn't believe them, but the answer rang true so she dropped the matter all together. Merely warning them to stay within sight of the guards, before apparently forgetting the matter entirely.

"Why won't she let you fight?" Bow asked, genuinely curious that evening as he restocked his quicksilver tipped arrows.

Glimmer groaned, huffing and letting herself be as childish as she damn well pleased about it knowing Bow wouldn't judge her for it. "I'm her only child."

"Okay?"

"...she was pregnant 32 times before me, Bow. Over protective and cowardly means I'm not even allowed to look at weapons now."

He nearly fumbled his arrow as he stared at her wide eyed. "Wow. And I thought 13 brothers was a lot. Well, at least it means she cares?"

Oh she wanted to tell him the truth. She wanted to tell him how all she cared about was keeping a fake peace. How she feared rebellion after so many losses trying to conquer Etheria within the last century. How she feared mutiny if any knew about the reality of the world, even though they all seemed to know it was already within their walls. The queen was sure they could keep it

contained as they had for centuries, that Etheria had brought it on themselves for being careless and greedy. Her mother didn't care about her safety, the queen cared about her like one might a prized and ancient heirloom. Glimmer was something she could show off, something to be coveted but not loved. No. Motherhood had not fit well with Queen Angella, and her attempts in Glimmer's youth to be kind and patient were long done with. No. Her mother did not care.

Queen Angella most likely didn't see her as a daughter at all. And if she did it only spoke more poorly against her for the way she forced Glimmer to bend to her will.

She was kept safe from the outside world out of fear, but within the castle walls Glimmer was not safe at all. Just another prisoner waiting to find out when they would be executed for the ghastly crime of being human instead of porcelain.

The angel blood almost chuckled, like a razor sharp smile that was pleased with her distress.

Glimmer wanted to tell him everything, but she could not.

"Perhaps." She turned away at the questioning look he gave her, unwilling to risk the backlash that might come to her. "I just wish she trusted me more. Believed in me instead of acting as if I'm some sort of pet that makes a mess inside the house. I know I could help if she'd let me!"

“I know you can, and I know you will.” His faith in her was more addictive than blood, his genuine belief in her bolstering and healing.

“Not while I’m here. I want to join the Force Captains on their hunts, but mother has refused to even let me watching the knight’s training anymore. If I could get out there…” Glimmer sighed. “If not for my hunting, then perhaps my blood could hold a clue. Father used to tell me how it was unique compared to what he uses at the college, but I'd rather be fighting that constantly healing in some hospital ward.”

Bow was quiet for a long time after that before haltingly telling her, “That’s where I’m going, the Horde, I mean. When we pass through Etheria on the way back to the library, I’m planning to slip away and join the Force Captains. Maybe we could go together?” He grinned at her, impish and excited, “It would be really nice to have someone I trust at my back.”

And there it finally was, her chance. Her one chance.

“I’d like that,” she was breathless with excitement, brain already spinning to come up with a way to leave, “I’d need to be disguised, but maybe…”

“Hide in the wagon?” Bow suggested.

"Bow, are you saying I'm a precious relic?" She'd smiled widely as he laughed.

But it was about as good as they were going to get, considering he would be leaving that evening.

She ran her fingers along the grass one last time, drawing the rest of the sigil and then stood, making a show of returning to her room before finally using one of her father's many magical glyphs. At least he'd finally been useful for something, as Glimmer blinked awake outside. She moved quickly and quietly to the stump Bow had surreptitiously hid one of the bottle of elixir he'd purchased on the way to Brightmoon, an elixir that when drunk made her ears ring with fuzz, head pound and go nearly thoughtless. *I will leave and become a hunter.* The reminder pulled her back, slowly but surely until she stood as little more than a ripple in the air. A quick stop at the now empty yard allowed her to procure her weapons, and she made her way with great haste to the wagon. One of the large wooden boxes stood open, it had stored a giant vase that was given to Brightmoon and would be returning empty for reuse at the library. Curiously, it was filled with fresh straw. Glimmer moved as slowly as she could and climbed into the box, glancing up in fear when someone loomed over her only to find Bow's smiling face. He winked and shut the box, sliding her a small bit of rope to make it appear as if it was nailed shut once more.

It took hours for them to finish and leave. Glimmer listened to the clip clop of hooves until she could hear they were on cobblestone and then peaked out the door to watch the Moon Lake passing by as they crossed the bridge. She wanted to cry, to scream with joy, to whoop and holler and celebrate when the wagon finally passed into the woods. Skirting around Etheria which was too dangerous

to travel at night. They traveled slowly, eventually stopping to make camp for the night. And when Bow opened the box, her heart was fit to burst for him.

Bow slowly untied one of the horses that had been pulling the wagon, guiding it over and helping Glimmer up onto its back and then they rode back the way they had come. Quietly a first, then faster, and faster until they both laughed with exhilaration. Yes, they would become hunters alright! It was early morning when they made it back to the small village at the end of Brightmoon's Bridge, the gates were unlocked to the city, and with their weapons the villagers let them through a a rough, "Happy hunting."

She was free. She was free and in Etheria. She was free and comforted Bow as they sold the horse, using the money to catch a buggy to the Cathedral Ward. She signed the paperwork given to her by a man who's hollow smile couldn't bring her down, and they were both brought to the tailor to be fitted with the regalia of the Horde. By the afternoon they were demonstrating their skills with their weapons, and that evening given their badges which allowed them to travel freely across the city day or night.

Yes. Glimmer was *free*.

She smiled at Bow as the gate opened briefly, letting them slip onto the streets of Etheria as the sun was setting, joining a group of other new hunters all awaiting their first blood.

Her blood was silent and still, dormant like everyone else's. She was ready, beyond ready, to finally join the hunt.

End Notes

Hear me out, I think blood lickers only show up when there's enough blood for them to be transformed but when I originally wrote this I thought blood lickers were unique to Cainhurst so I'm moving forward with some older theories from the fandom in general but I'm gonna cling to that one like I'm dying.

Anyways, Glimmer and Bow are off and I'm sure nothing bad can come of that! :) By howdy, I'm sure they will have a great time and there will be no consequences to face from ancient undying entities with a vested interest in them somewhere down the line.

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